

Gabe Sager

MART120

9/3/26

Reflection Paper- Culture and Learning Styles

The Scientific American piece's core finding surprised me a bit! The review of the scientific literature on learning styles found little support for the idea that people learn best when instruction matches their self-identified style, and a follow-up study found something even more telling: most students don't actually study in ways that match their own reported learning style, and the minority who do showed no better performance than everyone else. So the "I'm a visual learner" framing is unsupported. It doesn't predict how people study on their own. What actually moves the needle, per the article, are strategies like spacing study sessions out over time, testing yourself on the material, and elaborating on it to build meaningful connections. None of which depend on figuring out your "type."

As said in this week's discussion, the article pushed back on something I'd mostly taken for granted: the idea that I learn better visually, or through hands-on practice, or whatever label seemed to fit. The research in the article found little evidence that matching instruction (or even your own study habits) to a "learning style" actually improves outcomes. Spacing out study sessions, testing yourself, and connecting new material to things you already understand *does* help. It has nothing to do with being a "type" of learner at all.

That's a little humbling, honestly. It suggests a lot of the "I just learn differently" explanation is more comforting than accurate, and that the harder, less glamorous strategies (like quizzing yourself instead of just rereading notes) are what really do the work.

Where I think it gets more interesting is cultural background. Even if "learning styles" in the VARK sense (visual/auditory/reading/kinesthetic) aren't well supported, I don't think that means everyone learns the same way regardless of background. Culture shapes so many things: how comfortable someone is asking questions in a group setting, whether they're used to learning through direct instruction versus hands-on trial and error, how much prior context they bring to a topic, and even what kind of feedback feels motivating versus discouraging.

To me, cultural experience means what made you, you. To me, that is recreating and getting outside, enjoying and protecting the environment, and practicing homesteading traditions while having the privilege to go to school. My honest answer is that learning styles in the popular sense probably don't matter much, but the *conditions* someone learns in, including cultural conditions, shape how effective spaced practice or self-testing actually land for that person.